

War Sends More Tremors Through a Shaken World Economy



ALTAF QADRI/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Iran, which attacked an Emirati oil facility, above, is still blocking the Strait of Hormuz despite a U.S. raid on a critical oil hub.

PENTAGON MEMO

Hegseth’s Vengeful Rhetoric Grew From Experience in Iraq

By GREG JAFFE

WASHINGTON — Long before President Trump chose him to lead the U.S. military, Pete Hegseth described the moral calling that had compelled him to volunteer to serve in Iraq. He was working on Wall Street in the summer of 2005 and had read an article about an insurgent who blew himself up, killing 18 Iraqi children. “To me, that

was the face of evil,” Mr. Hegseth told The Princeton Alumni Weekly, adding, “That sent to me a signal that I need to do my part not to let that ideology win in Iraq.” He deployed to the war-torn city of Samarra a short time later. Today, Mr. Hegseth describes the mission and moral purpose animating the war in Iran, now in its third week, in starkly differ-

ent terms. The goal, he said recently, is to unleash “death and destruction from the sky all day long.” Instead of seeking justice, U.S. forces are pursuing vengeance against an implacable foe. “Their war on Americans has become our retribution,” he vowed. For decades, presidents and their secretaries of defense have framed American military interventions in altruistic terms. Even

though the truth was often more complicated, they cast U.S. troops as liberators bringing democracy and freedom to those living under tyranny and oppression. Mr. Hegseth has largely dispensed with that talk. His bellicose, at times vengeful, rhetoric reflects his belief that the United States’ lofty goals in Iraq and Afghanistan caused the military

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At Synagogue, Race to Shield Young Targets

By JULIE BOSMAN and KATHERINE ROSMAN

The bang that shattered the afternoon on Thursday at Temple Israel in West Bloomfield, Mich., was so loud, so inexplicable, that several rabbis and staff members in the building rushed into the hallway all at once. A truck had rammed through the building doors and down a corridor, past the nursery where infants slept, veering toward the gym where children played. Debris was falling from the ceiling and crumpled walls. Rabbi Arianna Gordon saw an overturned stroller surrounded by broken glass and a security guard rushing by with his weapon drawn. Then the sound of gunfire ricocheted through the building, reaching the administrative offices and classrooms, and the ears of dozens of children enrolled in the preschool. The truck became engulfed in flames, filling the halls and offices with smoke. “We needed to get away and get

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NETHERLANDS BLASTS No one was hurt in explosions at a Jewish school and a synagogue. PAGE 13



PHOTOGRAPHS BY GABRIELA BHASKAR/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Death Valley in Full Bloom

People have been flocking to see the bonanza of wildflowers that has transformed the hottest, driest place in North America. It has been called the most abundant bloom in a decade. Page 14.

10 Men With Weapons Set Out for Cuba by Boat. What Were They Trying to Do?

By PATRICIA MAZZEI and DAVID C. ADAMS

MIAMI — Before Héctor Cruz Correa left his home in South Florida for an ill-fated boat trip to Cuba last month, he told his mother that he was going fishing. He asked her to make his favorite beef soup for the trip. Another man, Roberto Álvarez Ávila, a father of three, told his

wife that he would see her after his shift as a Walmart security guard. A third, Conrado Galindo Sariol, who had spent eight years in a Cuban prison, told his wife he was going to work delivering packages. None of them returned home. The three men were among 10 Cuban immigrants who, according to the Cuban government, stowed a stockpile of weapons on

two boats in the Florida Keys, set sail and wound up in an armed confrontation with the Cuban coast guard about a mile off the island’s northern coast. The government called it a foiled terrorist attack. Four of the men, including Mr. Cruz Correa, died in the firefight on Feb. 25. Mr. Álvarez, who had been shot, died nine days later. The five others were all injured

and remain detained in Cuba. More than two weeks later, what the men intended to do that day remains a mystery. They knew each other from TikTok group chats and fringe organizations dedicated to freeing Cuba from communism. Most of them lived and worked in and around Miami and Tampa, two hubs of anti-Castro sentiment. Their relatives remain skeptical of the Cu-

ban government’s account. Yet some Cubans in Miami have started to believe that the men might have convinced themselves that a few anti-communist militants could take on the Cuban dictatorship. Cuba’s economy is on the brink of collapse. Its Communist government looks weaker than at any other point in recent history. After

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Fallout From Prolonged Conflict With Iran Could Bring ‘Catastrophic Consequences’

By PATRICIA COHEN

Bombs are exploding in Iran and the Middle East, but the fallout is rattling households and businesses in neighborhoods all over the globe. In Kansas, home buyers saw 30-year mortgage rates edge above 6 percent last week. In western India, families mourning the death of a loved one discovered that gas-fired crematories had been temporarily closed. In Hanoi, Vietnam, gas station owners posted “sold out” signs. In Kenya, tea growers and traders worried their exports to Iran would rot on the dock. And across the United States, Canada, Europe, Britain and Mexico, farmers blanched at the surge in fertilizer costs. The widening war in Iran has delivered a stunning punch to a worldwide economy that has already been walloped by a breakdown of the international trading order, war in Ukraine and President Trump’s chaotic policymaking. “This really is the big one,” David Goldwyn, a former U.S. diplomat and U.S. Energy Department official, said of the shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz, the world’s most important choke point for oil. It is the emergency scenario everyone feared, he said. Cargo deliveries have been stranded, shipping charges have increased and insurance premiums have skyrocketed. Yes, the price of gas at the pump is affected. But so is the price of food, medicine, airplane tickets, electricity, cooking oil, semiconductors and more. A drawn-out war between the United States and Iran could have

“catastrophic consequences” for the world’s oil market and the global economy, Amin Nasser, chief executive of Saudi Aramco, the world’s largest oil and gas company, warned last week. Yet even if the war, which began on Feb. 28 when the United States and Israel struck Iran, wraps up relatively quickly, this latest upheaval is sending consumers, workers and employers on another unnerving and unpredictable ride. It’s not just that small business owners and corporate executives must once again re-evaluate their supply chains, manage additional price increases and track shifting restrictions on who they can do business with. Or that the added uncertainty undermines confidence, making consumers reluctant to spend and businesses reluctant to invest. It’s that this remapping of power dynamics in the Middle East could set off a string of consequences whose full force might not be known for months or years. Meg Jacobs, the author of “Panic at the Pump: The Energy Crisis and The Transformation of American Politics in the 1970s,” pointed out that prices didn’t immediately go back down after the oil embargo in 1973 and 1974. They remained high for the rest of the decade. The supply situation is completely different today, with many more producers, Ms. Jacobs emphasized. But the crisis that the Organization of Arab Petroleum Exporting Countries created with its embargo set off a chain of

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GLOBAL VISION Secretary of State Marco Rubio is executing the president’s goal of regime compliance rather than regime change. PAGE 10
FIIGHT FROM ABOVE A guide to the primary weapons that each side in the conflict is using to achieve its objectives. PAGE 12
TERMS OF WAR As the price of U.S. partnership, Israel’s prime minister has had to defer to President Trump. News Analysis. PAGE 11

How Bezos Upended The Post With a Strategy Fit for Amazon

This article is by Benjamin Mullin, Erik Wemple and Katie Robertson.

Jeff Bezos called Matt Murray, the executive editor of The Washington Post, in late November to send an urgent message: Please do not quit. Mr. Murray had known for weeks that Mr. Bezos, the billionaire founder of Amazon and owner of The Post, was planning widespread layoffs to stem over \$100 million in annual losses. But Mr. Murray felt sidelined in the preparations and had recently told the company’s chief executive, Will Lewis, that he was leaving the paper, according to two

people with knowledge of the discussions. Mr. Bezos told Mr. Murray that he wanted him to help shape a newsroom that would be financially sustainable far into the future, the two people said. And Mr. Bezos pitched his strategy: Reduce the newsroom’s budget by half and double the productivity of those who remained, all while protecting some core parts of The Post’s coverage, like investigative journalism. Mr. Murray said he would take on that challenge. In a single call, Mr. Bezos had set a new course for The Post and upended the power balance between his top news editor, Mr.

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Lives of 2 Soldiers Diverged
Lt. Col. Brandon Shah flew hundreds of combat missions before being killed in his Old Dominion University classroom by a radicalized veteran. PAGE 18

ARTS & LEISURE

Who Wasn’t Right for a Role?
A new Oscar will recognize excellence in casting a movie. Yet it can be fun to look at past mismatches. We’ve made a list of some of our favorites. PAGE 8

SUNDAY STYLES

Captivating Complexions
The makeup artist Nina Park has built a long and impressive client list by helping celebrities “really look like themselves.” PAGE 1

SUNDAY BUSINESS

Wealthy, but Less Charitable
It was once trendy among the world’s billionaires to sign the Giving Pledge, but the project has fallen on hard times as a philanthropic dream dims. PAGE 6

SUNDAY OPINION

Michelle Goldberg PAGE 6

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